still able to broadly provide domestic security until around 2005–6. However, this too changed as the effects of the war in Afghanistan, especially after 9/11, started to take their toll.[6] Until recently ordinary Pakistanis saw the role of the state not as one that necessarily provided basic amenities such as infrastructure, education and health, but one which at least provided security. As terrorist groups, both domestic and foreign, started to fight the Pakistani establishment, it was mostly ordinary citizens who suffered. Since 2008 the increased violence across the country in the form of suicide attacks and random bomb blasts has meant that the state is no longer fulfilling this role either, increasing the alienation across the country.

Over the seven decades since independence Pakistan has provided fewer and fewer basic social goods to its citizens and the political elites have failed to establish a relationship even in democratic times, reinforcing a stark class divide. Pakistan is ranked at 150 in the Human Development Index 2017 (UNDP 2018). According to a UNDP report, 'In 1987/88 the Gini coefficient, which measures income inequality, was 0.35; by 2013/14 it had risen to 0.41. Pakistan's richest 20 per cent now consume seven times more than the poorest 20%' (UNDP 2016b, p. 1). There is further regional disparity. In 2016 the Multidimensional Poverty Index 'found that 54.6% of rural Pakistanis experienced poverty compared to 9.3% in cities' (UNDP 2016b). Furthermore, 'multidimensional poverty stands at 31.5% in Punjab but rises to 73.7% in FATA' (UNDP 2016b). The level of disparity is evident in the fact that 'multidimensional poverty in Islamabad, Lahore, Karachi, and Rawalpindi is below 10%; it exceeds 90% in Killa Abdullah, Harnai, Barkhan, Sherani Kohistan' (UNDP 2016b). The Youth Development Index (YDI) that measures 'health, education, employment and civic and political participation' of youth between the ages of 15 and 29 for 183 countries, placed Pakistan at 154 in 2016, 'the only non-African country amongst the ten lowest-ranked Commonwealth countries' (UNDP 2017, p. 32). Regionally, Pakistan trails behind all other South Asian countries except Afghanistan in education indicators, 'with a youth literacy of barely 70.7%'. While many of the country's woes are often explained by the thirty-odd years of military dictatorships that plagued the country between 1958–69, 1977–88 and 1998–2008,[7] a closer look at these three decades shows that while citizens' rights were certainly abolished or violated, the social contract side of the state as a provider of services, that is, state responsibility, did continue, mostly unabated. Under military rule, the state was, if anything, more present in people's lives than it was during times of democratically elected governments.